Haligric Research Integration Series

CHRISTIANITY — QUICK REFERENCE COMPANION

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Denominations, Sub-Denominations, Thought Forms, and Theological Systems — The Complete Comparative Map

---

Two billion Christians. Thousands of denominations. Dozens of named theological systems. One carpenter from Nazareth as the claimed origin point of all of them. This document is the map — a quick-reference companion that lets you locate any denomination, any theological term, any named thought form in the full landscape of Christian tradition. Each entry gives you what you need to place it: when it started, who started it, what makes it distinct, and where it sits in relation to its neighbors.

This document works alongside the individual denomination deep-dives in this series. For the full account of any tradition — its theology, its ceremonies, its controversies — go to the dedicated document. This companion gives you the comparative map that the individual documents do not.

Contents

How to Use This Document....3
The Big Map — Christianity's Major Branches....00
Part One — The Catholic Traditions....5
Part Two — The Orthodox Traditions....6
Part Three — The Protestant Reformation Branches....7
Part Four — Post-Reformation Protestant Movements....8
Part Five — American-Origin Denominations....9
Part Six — The Pentecostal and Charismatic Branches....11
Part Seven — The Edges and Independents....12
Part Eight — Named Theological Thought Forms....13
Part Nine — Theological Systems That Cut Across Denominations....16
Part Ten — Quick Comparison: What Each Branch Believes....18
How the Documents in This Series Relate....20

How to Use This Document

Each denomination entry gives you five things: when it was founded and by whom, its core distinctives (what makes it different from its nearest neighbors), its key figures, its major subgroups, and a note on its current state or most important controversy. Read the entry for any denomination you encounter and you will know where it sits on the map.

The thought form entries give you four things: the origin (who coined the term and when), the core claim (what the thought form asserts that others dispute), the central tension (what it is in conflict with), and who holds it today. These are the named theological systems — Calvinism, Arminianism, Thomism — that circulate across denominations and often cause more confusion than the denominations themselves, because a Baptist can be a Calvinist and a Methodist can be an Arminian without those terms appearing in the denomination's name.

A note on the word "denomination": in this document it refers to any formally organized Christian body with a name, a governing structure, and a defined theological identity. Independent churches, house churches, and parachurch organizations are noted where relevant but not listed as denominations. The edges section covers the traditions that sit at the boundary of mainstream Christian recognition.

The Big Map — Christianity's Major Branches

Christianity divided into its three largest branches approximately as follows:

Catholic (1.35 billion): The tradition claiming unbroken institutional continuity from the apostles through the papacy. Divided into Roman Catholic (the vast majority) and the Eastern Catholic Churches (in communion with Rome but using Eastern liturgical rites).

Orthodox (260–300 million): The tradition that separated from Rome in the Great Schism of 1054, maintaining apostolic continuity without papal authority. Divided into Eastern Orthodox (Greek, Russian, Serbian, Romanian, etc.) and Oriental Orthodox (Coptic, Ethiopian, Armenian, Syrian — separated earlier over the Council of Chalcedon in 451 CE).

Protestant (900 million+): All the traditions that emerged from or after the 16th-century Reformation initiated by Martin Luther in 1517. Internal divisions are vast and complex. The major groupings: Lutheran, Reformed/Presbyterian, Anglican/Episcopal, Methodist, Baptist, Pentecostal, Evangelical, and dozens of smaller movements.

A fourth category sometimes used: Restorationist or Independent (100–200 million): Movements that reject the Catholic-Orthodox-Protestant historical framework and claim to restore the original New Testament church. Includes LDS/Mormon, Jehovah's Witnesses, Church of Christ, and others.

The key fault lines between these branches:

Catholic vs. Protestant: Authority. Catholic theology locates final authority in Scripture AND Tradition AND the Magisterium (the teaching authority of the Church). Protestant theology (in its classical form) locates final authority in Scripture alone (Sola Scriptura).

Catholic/Orthodox vs. each other: Primacy. Both claim apostolic succession. They disagree on whether the Bishop of Rome has universal jurisdiction (Catholic yes, Orthodox no) and on the filioque clause in the Nicene Creed (the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father AND the Son — Catholic; only from the Father — Orthodox).

Protestant vs. Protestant: The Reformation opened questions that Protestants have answered differently ever since. Baptism (infant or adult only?), the Lord's Supper (how is Christ present?), church governance (episcopal, presbyterian, or congregational?), predestination (Calvinist or Arminian?), and the gifts of the Spirit (cessationist or continuationist?) are the primary fault lines within Protestantism.

Part One — The Catholic Traditions

~1.35 billion members worldwide. The largest single Christian body.

Roman Catholic Church

Founded: 33 CE (apostolic origin claimed); present institutional form developed over centuries; Great Schism 1054; Council of Trent 1545–1563 defines modern Catholicism; Vatican II 1962–1965 most recent major reform

Core distinctives: Papal infallibility (defined 1870); seven sacraments; transubstantiation (Christ literally present in Eucharist); purgatory; veneration of Mary and saints; apostolic succession through unbroken episcopal lineage; authority of Scripture + Tradition + Magisterium

Key figures: Peter (first bishop of Rome); Gregory the Great; Thomas Aquinas; Ignatius of Loyola; Teresa of Ávila; Pope John XXIII (Vatican II); Pope Francis (current)

Major subgroups: Within Roman Catholicism: traditional/Tridentine (prefer the pre-Vatican II Latin Mass); progressive (emphasize Vatican II reforms); charismatic Catholic (integrate Pentecostal gifts); liberation theology Catholics (social justice emphasis)

Full treatment in the Roman Catholicism master document in this series.

Eastern Catholic Churches

Founded: Various dates; these are Eastern churches that entered or re-entered communion with Rome while retaining their Eastern liturgical rites

Core distinctives: In full communion with the Pope; use Eastern liturgical traditions (Byzantine, Coptic, Ethiopian, Syriac, Armenian, Chaldean, Maronite); married clergy permitted (unlike Roman Catholic); distinct sacred traditions from their Orthodox counterparts

Key figures: Varies by specific church

Major subgroups: 23 distinct Eastern Catholic churches: Byzantine (Greek Catholic, Ukrainian Greek Catholic, Melkite); Coptic Catholic; Ethiopian Catholic; Maronite (largest, based in Lebanon); Chaldean; Armenian Catholic; Syriac Catholic; and others

Often confused with Orthodox churches — the key difference is communion with Rome. The Maronite Church (~3.5 million) has always maintained Rome connection; others reunited at various points.

Part Two — The Orthodox Traditions

~260–300 million members worldwide. Second-largest Christian body.

Eastern Orthodox

Founded: Apostolic origin claimed; formally separated from Rome in the Great Schism of 1054

Core distinctives: No papal authority; governed by communion of autocephalous (self-governing) national churches; Ecumenical Patriarch of Constantinople holds honorary primacy; seven ecumenical councils as doctrinal authority; theosis (deification — the process of becoming like God) as central soteriological concept; Divine Liturgy of John Chrysostom as primary worship form; icons as windows to the sacred

Key figures: John Chrysostom; Basil the Great; Gregory the Theologian; Maximus the Confessor; Gregory Palamas; Seraphim of Sarov

Major subgroups: Greek Orthodox; Russian Orthodox (largest, ~100 million); Serbian Orthodox; Romanian Orthodox; Bulgarian Orthodox; Georgian Orthodox; Antiochian Orthodox; Orthodox Church in America; many others — all in communion with each other

Full treatment in the Eastern Orthodoxy master document in this series.

Oriental Orthodox

Founded: Separated from what became Eastern Orthodoxy in 451 CE over the Council of Chalcedon's definition of Christ's two natures (divine and human)

Core distinctives: Miaphysite Christology: Christ has one united divine-human nature, not two separate natures. Sometimes incorrectly called "Monophysite" (one nature only) — Oriental Orthodox reject this label as misrepresentation. Ancient liturgical traditions; Ethiopia's church claims direct descent from Queen of Sheba and King Solomon

Key figures: Cyril of Alexandria; Dioscorus of Alexandria; Frumentius (Ethiopian church)

Major subgroups: Coptic Orthodox (Egypt, ~10–15 million); Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo (largest Oriental Orthodox church, ~40–50 million); Eritrean Orthodox; Armenian Apostolic; Syriac Orthodox; Malankara Orthodox (India)

These are some of the oldest Christian churches in the world. The Ethiopian Orthodox Church has the largest membership.

Part Three — The Protestant Reformation Branches

The Protestant tradition began in 1517 with Martin Luther's challenge to the Catholic Church. The primary Reformation branches:

Lutheranism

Founded: 1517 — Martin Luther posts 95 Theses; Lutheran Church formally organized at Augsburg 1530

Core distinctives: Justification by faith alone (Sola Fide) as the central article of faith; Scripture alone as authority (Sola Scriptura); two sacraments (Baptism and the Lord's Supper); Real Presence in the Eucharist — Christ truly present in, with, and under the bread and wine (distinct from Catholic transubstantiation and Reformed "memorial" views); liturgical worship retained from Catholic tradition

Key figures: Martin Luther; Philip Melanchthon; Johann Sebastian Bach (cultural expression)

Major subgroups: Evangelical Lutheran Church in America (ELCA — more progressive); Lutheran Church Missouri Synod (LCMS — more conservative); Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod (WELS — most conservative); Lutheran World Federation globally; Scandinavian Lutheran state churches

Full treatment in the Lutheranism master document in this series.

Reformed / Presbyterian

Founded: 1536 — John Calvin's Institutes of the Christian Religion; Reformed tradition developed in Switzerland, France, Netherlands, Scotland

Core distinctives: Sovereignty of God as the organizing theological principle; TULIP (Total depravity, Unconditional election, Limited atonement, Irresistible grace, Perseverance of the saints — see Calvinism in thought forms); two sacraments; Lord's Supper as spiritual presence (not physical); Presbyterian governance (ruled by elders/presbyters in representative assemblies rather than bishops); Westminster Confession of Faith (1647) as primary confessional standard

Key figures: John Calvin; Ulrich Zwingli; John Knox (Scotland); Jonathan Edwards; Abraham Kuyper

Major subgroups: Presbyterian Church USA (PCUSA — progressive); Presbyterian Church in America (PCA — conservative); Reformed Church in America; Christian Reformed Church; Associate Reformed Presbyterian; Orthodox Presbyterian Church; United Reformed Churches

Full treatment in the Reformed/Calvinism master document in this series.

Anglican / Episcopalian

Founded: 1534 — Henry VIII's Act of Supremacy separates the Church of England from Rome; theological identity shaped by Thomas Cranmer's Book of Common Prayer (1549, 1552)

Core distinctives: The "via media" (middle way) between Catholicism and Reformed Protestantism; episcopal governance (bishops in apostolic succession); the Book of Common Prayer as defining liturgical authority; the Thirty-Nine Articles as doctrinal standard; broad theological tolerance ("comprehensiveness") — Anglicanism contains Catholic, evangelical, and liberal streams simultaneously

Key figures: Henry VIII (political founder); Thomas Cranmer (theological founder); Richard Hooker; C.S. Lewis; William Wilberforce

Major subgroups: Church of England (established church of England); Episcopal Church USA (TEC — progressive); Anglican Church in North America (ACNA — conservative, formed 2009 over sexuality controversies); Anglican Church of Australia; Church of Nigeria; and approximately 85 member churches of the Anglican Communion worldwide

Full treatment in the Anglicanism master document in this series. Currently experiencing major global division between progressive and conservative wings.

Part Four — Post-Reformation Protestant Movements

Methodism

Founded: 1738 — John Wesley's conversion experience; Methodist societies organized within the Church of England; separate denomination formed in America 1784

Core distinctives: Arminian theology (free will, prevenient grace — see Arminianism in thought forms); entire sanctification / Christian perfection (the possibility of a second work of grace that cleanses from sin's root — Wesley's most distinctive doctrine); quadrilateral of authority (Scripture, Tradition, Reason, Experience); social holiness ("no holiness but social holiness" — Wesley); circuit-rider evangelism model

Key figures: John Wesley; Charles Wesley (hymns); Francis Asbury (America); William Booth (Salvation Army)

Major subgroups: United Methodist Church (UMC — largest, recently split over homosexuality); Free Methodist Church; Wesleyan Church; Church of the Nazarene; Salvation Army; African Methodist Episcopal (AME); AME Zion; Christian Methodist Episcopal

Full treatment in the Methodism master document in this series. The UMC split in 2024 produced the Global Methodist Church (traditionalist).

Baptist

Founded: ca. 1609 — John Smyth baptizes himself and others in Amsterdam; first Baptist church in England; General Baptists (Arminian) and Particular Baptists (Calvinist) emerge separately

Core distinctives: Believer's baptism only (no infant baptism — hence "Baptist"); baptism by immersion only (in most Baptist bodies); congregational governance (each local church autonomous); soul competency (every individual directly accountable to God, no priestly mediation); symbolic Lord's Supper; strong emphasis on religious liberty

Key figures: John Smyth; Roger Williams (religious liberty); Charles Spurgeon; Billy Graham (Southern Baptist)

Major subgroups: Southern Baptist Convention (SBC — largest Protestant denomination in USA, ~14 million); American Baptist Churches USA; Independent Fundamental Baptists (IFB — extremely conservative); National Baptist Convention (predominantly African American, ~5 million); Progressive National Baptist Convention; International Mission Board (SBC mission arm)

Full treatment in the Baptist Tradition master document in this series. SBC has been through significant controversy over sexual abuse cover-up (2018–present) and complementarianism/egalitarianism debates.

Part Five — American-Origin Denominations

Several major Christian movements originated specifically in the American context:

LDS / Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

Founded: 1830 — Joseph Smith organizes the church in Fayette, New York, following claimed visions and the Book of Mormon

Core distinctives: Additional scripture (Book of Mormon, Doctrine and Covenants, Pearl of Great Price alongside Bible); continuing revelation through a living prophet; pre-mortal existence of souls; potential for humans to progress toward godhood (exaltation); baptism for the dead; eternal families sealed in temples; law of tithing; Word of Wisdom (dietary restrictions); lay priesthood structure; former polygamy (officially ended 1890)

Key figures: Joseph Smith; Brigham Young; Gordon B. Hinckley

Major subgroups: Main LDS Church (Salt Lake City-based, ~17 million members); Community of Christ (formerly RLDS — more progressive, ordains women, headquartered in Independence MO); Fundamentalist LDS groups (practice polygamy, not recognized by main church)

Full treatment in the LDS/Mormon master document in this series. Considered by most mainstream Christians as outside orthodox Trinitarian Christianity due to distinctive theology of God.

Church of Christ / Churches of Christ / Christian Churches

Founded: 1830s — Restoration Movement led by Barton W. Stone and Alexander Campbell, seeking to restore the New Testament church by abandoning creeds and traditions

Core distinctives: No creed but the New Testament; a cappella worship only (in Churches of Christ — no instrumental music in worship, based on silence of Scripture); weekly Lord's Supper; baptism by immersion for remission of sins (not merely symbolic — salvation connected to baptism); congregational autonomy; rejects denominational structure and labels itself as simply "the church"

Key figures: Barton W. Stone; Alexander Campbell; Walter Scott

Major subgroups: Churches of Christ (non-instrumental, ~1.5 million in USA); Christian Churches and Churches of Christ (instrumental, moderate); Christian Church (Disciples of Christ) — most progressive, part of National Council of Churches

These three groups share the same historical origin but differ significantly today. The name "Church of Christ" is used by the most theologically conservative wing.

Seventh-day Adventism

Founded: 1844 — following the "Great Disappointment" when William Miller's predicted Second Coming did not occur; formally organized 1863

Core distinctives: Saturday Sabbath (seventh-day worship, not Sunday — hence "Seventh-day"); Saturday as the identifying mark of true Christianity; imminent Second Coming; state of the dead as "soul sleep" (no consciousness between death and resurrection); health message (vegetarianism encouraged, no alcohol, no tobacco, no unclean meats); Ellen White as authoritative prophetic voice; investigative judgment (a specific atonement doctrine unique to Adventism)

Key figures: William Miller; Ellen G. White; James White; Joseph Bates

Major subgroups: General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists (~22 million — one of the fastest-growing denominations globally); some independent/offshoots that emphasize Ellen White more strictly

Full treatment in the Seventh-day Adventism master document in this series.

Jehovah's Witnesses

Founded: 1872 — Charles Taze Russell begins Bible study group; Watch Tower Society organized 1884; name "Jehovah's Witnesses" adopted 1931

Core distinctives: Non-Trinitarian: Jehovah is the only true God; Jesus is a created divine being (the archangel Michael), not co-equal with God; the Holy Spirit is an active force, not a person; no hell — the dead are unconscious; 144,000 will reign with Christ in heaven, remainder of faithful will live on a restored paradise earth; blood transfusions forbidden; no celebration of holidays

(Christmas, birthdays, etc.); no military service; door-to-door evangelism required; organizational authority of the Governing Body

Key figures: Charles Taze Russell; Joseph Franklin Rutherford (shaped modern movement)

Major subgroups: Organizational structure: Governing Body (headquarters in Warwick, NY); Kingdom Halls (local congregations); Bethel (branch facilities); circuit overseers

Full treatment in the Jehovah's Witnesses master document in this series. ~8.7 million active members globally.

Part Six — The Pentecostal and Charismatic Branches

Pentecostal and charismatic traditions are the fastest-growing form of Christianity globally.

Classical Pentecostalism

Founded: 1906 — Azusa Street Revival, Los Angeles, led by William J. Seymour; traces theological roots to the 1901 Bethel Bible College in Topeka, Kansas (Agnes Ozman first speaks in tongues)

Core distinctives: Baptism in the Holy Spirit as a second definite work of grace following salvation, evidenced by speaking in tongues (glossolalia); the gifts of the Spirit (tongues, prophecy, healing, miracles) as normative for today; divine healing in the atonement; premillennial Second Coming; experiential, emotional worship; the supernatural as daily reality

Key figures: William J. Seymour; Charles Parham; Aimee Semple McPherson; Oral Roberts; Jimmy Swaggart

Major subgroups: Assemblies of God (~70 million globally, ~3 million USA — largest classical Pentecostal denomination); Church of God (Cleveland, TN); Church of God in Christ (COGIC — predominantly African American, ~6 million USA); Foursquare Church; United Pentecostal Church International (Oneness Pentecostal — non-Trinitarian, baptism in Jesus name only); International Church of the Foursquare Gospel

Full treatment in the Pentecostalism master document in this series. Oneness Pentecostals are considered outside orthodox Trinitarianism by most mainstream Christians.

Charismatic Movement

Founded: 1960s — began within mainline and Catholic churches; Dennis Bennett (Episcopal priest) declares Spirit baptism 1960; Catholic Charismatic Renewal begins 1967 at Duquesne University

Core distinctives: Same emphasis on spiritual gifts as Classical Pentecostalism, but operating within existing denominations rather than as separate churches; often called "renewal" rather than a distinct denomination; Catholic Charismatic Renewal is the largest single charismatic movement (~120 million)

Key figures: Dennis Bennett; Ralph Wilkerson; Kevin Ranaghan; Pope Francis (sympathetic to Catholic Charismatic Renewal)

Major subgroups: Present within Roman Catholic, Episcopal, Lutheran, Methodist, Presbyterian, Baptist and virtually all other denominations; also independent charismatic churches

Not a denomination but a movement within denominations. Distinct from Classical Pentecostalism by staying within existing church structures.

Neo-Charismatic / New Apostolic Reformation (NAR)

Founded: 1980s–1990s — emerging from charismatic movement; C. Peter Wagner coins "New Apostolic Reformation" 1990s

Core distinctives: Restored offices of apostle and prophet as governing the contemporary church; "dominionism" — the mandate for Christians to take authority over all seven spheres of society (government, business, media, arts, education, family, religion — the "Seven Mountain Mandate"); strategic spiritual warfare; regional and territorial demons; "signs and wonders" evangelism

Key figures: C. Peter Wagner; Bill Hamon; Cindy Jacobs; Dutch Sheets; Lou Engle; IHOP (International House of Prayer, Mike Bickle)

Major subgroups: No central structure; networks including Global Spheres, Generals International, HIM (Harvest International Ministry); major individual churches: Bethel Church (Redding CA, Bill Johnson); IHOP Kansas City; Global Awakening (Randy Clark)

Considered controversial within evangelical Christianity; associated with specific political engagement; criticized for prophetic accountability failures (2020 election prophecies).

Part Seven — The Edges and Independents

These traditions sit at or beyond the boundary of mainstream Christian recognition:

Christian Science

Founded: 1866 (Mary Baker Eddy's healing experience); formally organized 1879

Core distinctives: Matter is unreal; disease and death are illusions of mortal mind; healing through prayer and correct understanding of spiritual reality; Jesus demonstrated dominion over matter; no sacraments; Christian Science practitioners as healers; the Bible and Eddy's Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures as dual authority

Key figures: Mary Baker Eddy

Major subgroups: Church of Christ, Scientist (no sub-groups — highly centralized); Christian Science Reading Rooms worldwide

Full treatment in the Christian Science master document in this series. Membership declining significantly (~40,000–50,000 active members now from a peak of ~200,000).

Unitarian Universalism (UU)

Founded: Unitarian roots: 16th century Transylvania; Universalist roots: 18th century America; merged 1961 as Unitarian Universalist Association

Core distinctives: No creed or required beliefs; seven principles (dignity of every person, justice, acceptance, spiritual growth, right of conscience, world community, interconnected web of existence); draws from multiple world religions; ordains all people regardless of gender or sexuality; post-Christian in most congregations — many UUs do not identify as Christian

Key figures: Michael Servetus (martyr for early Unitarianism); John Murray (Universalism); William Ellery Channing; Ralph Waldo Emerson

Major subgroups: Unitarian Universalist Association (~1,000 congregations, ~150,000 members in USA)

Full treatment in the Unitarian Universalism master document in this series. Debated whether UU is a Christian denomination — most branches of Christianity do not recognize it as such.

Non-Denominational / Independent Evangelical

Founded: Accelerated growth from 1970s onward; no single founding moment

Core distinctives: No denominational affiliation; local church authority; typically evangelical in theology (born-again conversion, biblical authority, evangelism); contemporary worship style; seeker-sensitive or attractional model; megachurch tendency; pastors often hold considerable authority without denominational accountability structure

Key figures: Bill Hybels (Willow Creek); Rick Warren (Saddleback); Andy Stanley (North Point); Joel Osteen (Lakewood — leans prosperity)

Major subgroups: No formal structure; networks include Acts 29 (Reformed evangelical church planting), Willow Creek Association, Vineyard USA, Calvary Chapel

The fastest-growing category in American Christianity by self-identification. Wide theological range from conservative Reformed to prosperity gospel.

Quakers (Religious Society of Friends)

Founded: 1647–1650 — George Fox begins preaching in England; first "Friends" gather

Core distinctives: No clergy; no sacraments; worship in silence waiting for the Inner Light (the Spirit of Christ in each person) to speak; some branches use prepared worship but traditional Quakers do not; testimony of peace (pacifism), equality, simplicity, integrity; historically active in abolitionism and social reform

Key figures: George Fox; William Penn; John Woolman; Lucretia Mott

Major subgroups: Friends General Conference (liberal, unprogrammed); Friends United Meeting (moderate); Evangelical Friends Church International (evangelical, programmed worship); Conservative Friends

Small (~300,000–400,000 worldwide) but historically disproportionate influence on social reform movements.

Part Eight — Named Theological Thought Forms

These are the named theological systems that circulate across denominational lines. A Baptist can be a Calvinist. A Methodist can be an Arminian. A Catholic can be a Thomist. Understanding these thought forms is often more important for understanding what a Christian actually believes than knowing their denomination.

Calvinism (Reformed Theology)

Origin: John Calvin (1509–1564), Geneva; systematized by the Synod of Dort (1618–1619) in response to Arminianism; acronym TULIP developed later as summary

Core claim: God's sovereignty is absolute and unconditional. The five points: Total Depravity (sin has affected every faculty of human nature — humans cannot choose God without divine intervention); Unconditional Election (God chose who would be saved before creation, not based on foreseen faith); Limited Atonement (Christ died specifically for the elect, not for all people); Irresistible Grace (when God calls the elect, they will inevitably respond); Perseverance of the Saints (true believers cannot ultimately fall away from salvation). Often summarized: God saves people, people do not choose God.

Central tension: With Arminianism: Can humans freely choose or reject God? Calvinism says no — the elect are saved by irresistible divine grace. Arminianism says yes — salvation can be rejected.

Who holds it today: Presbyterian and Reformed denominations (PCA, RCUS); many Southern Baptist pastors and congregations; Reformed Baptist churches; much of the 9Marks network; Together for the Gospel (T4G) conference community; Westminster Seminary tradition.

Arminianism

Origin: Jacobus Arminius (1560–1609), Netherlands; formalized in the Five Articles of the Remonstrants (1610) as a response to Calvinist conclusions

Core claim: Human free will is real and consequential. The five articles: Conditional election (God elected those He foreknew would believe); Universal atonement (Christ died for all people); Prevenient grace (God's grace enables but does not compel belief — humans can resist it); Resistible grace (the Holy Spirit can be resisted); Conditional perseverance (believers can fall from grace — salvation can be lost). Often summarized: God makes salvation possible for all; humans choose to receive or reject it.

Central tension: With Calvinism: Is grace resistible? Arminians say yes. Can the saved lose their salvation? Arminians say potentially yes; Calvinists say no (eternal security). Who did Christ die for? Arminians: everyone; Calvinists: the elect only.

Who holds it today: Methodist and Wesleyan denominations; Assemblies of God and most Pentecostal traditions; most Free Will Baptists; many non-denominational churches; Church of the Nazarene.

Thomism

Origin: Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274); synthesized Aristotelian philosophy with Christian theology in the Summa Theologica; became the official philosophical framework of the Catholic Church (confirmed at Council of Trent 1545)

Core claim: Reason and faith are compatible and complementary, not in conflict. Natural theology: the existence and nature of God can be known through reason alone (the Five Ways — five philosophical arguments for God's existence). Analogical language about God: human language about God works by analogy, not univocation or equivocation. Transubstantiation: the Aristotelian categories of substance and accidents explain how the Eucharist is Christ's body and blood while retaining the accidents (appearance) of bread and wine. Natural law ethics: moral truth is knowable through reason.

Central tension: With Protestant theology: the role of natural reason in knowing God; the philosophical framework for sacramental theology; the relationship between philosophy and theology.

Who holds it today: Roman Catholic theology officially; Dominican order as primary custodians; Neo-Thomist revival in 20th century (Jacques Maritain, Etienne Gilson); Thomistic Institute (Washington DC); many Catholic seminaries globally.

Augustinianism

Origin: Augustine of Hippo (354–430); foundational for both Catholic and Protestant theology; his major works On the Trinity, Confessions, City of God, and anti-Pelagian writings shaped Western Christianity

Core claim: Human nature is radically fallen after Adam's sin (original sin as inherited guilt and corruption, not merely inherited tendency). Grace is absolutely necessary and sovereign — humans cannot move toward God without divine initiative. Predestination: God eternally chose who would be saved. The two cities: the City of God (organized by love of God) and the City of Man (organized by love of self) run through all history. The church is not identical with the Kingdom of God.

Central tension: With Pelagianism (the 5th-century view Augustine opposed): Can humans choose good without divine grace? Augustine emphatically: no. With semi-Pelagianism: Is the first move toward God from the human or divine side? Augustine: always divine.

Who holds it today: Both Catholic and Protestant claim Augustine. Calvin called himself an Augustinian. Catholic theology modified Augustine through Aquinas. The Calvinist-Arminian debate is substantially a debate about which reading of Augustine is correct.

Wesleyan Theology

Origin: John Wesley (1703–1791); developed as a synthesis of Arminian free grace theology with a specific doctrine of sanctification

Core claim: Prevenient grace: God's grace goes before all human response, enabling but not compelling faith. Entire sanctification (Christian perfection): after conversion, a second definite work of grace is possible and desirable in which the root of sin (the sinful nature's inclination) is cleansed — the believer enters a state of "perfect love" oriented entirely toward God. This is not sinless perfection in an absolute sense but freedom from the dominion and desire of sin. Salvation is by grace through faith; faith is made possible by prevenient grace; entire sanctification is the telos (goal) of the saved life.

Central tension: With Calvinist Reformed theology: Is entire sanctification possible before death? Calvinists say sanctification is lifelong and complete only at death/glorification. Wesley said a second crisis of sanctification is possible in this life. With Lutheranism: Wesley was more optimistic about the transformative possibilities of grace in the Christian life.

Who holds it today: Methodist and Wesleyan denominations; Church of the Nazarene; Free Methodist Church; Salvation Army; Holiness movement broadly.

Dispensationalism

Origin: John Nelson Darby (1800–1882), Plymouth Brethren; popularized in America by the Scofield Reference Bible (1909) and Dallas Theological Seminary; Hal Lindsey's The Late Great Planet Earth (1970) brought it to mass culture

Core claim: God has dealt with humanity through distinct successive "dispensations" (ages/economies) — typically seven: Innocence (Eden), Conscience (Adam to Noah), Human Government (Noah to Abraham), Promise (Abraham to Moses), Law (Moses to Christ), Grace (Church Age, present), Kingdom (Millennial reign). Each dispensation involves a different test and a different response from God when humanity fails. The Church is a parenthesis in God's prophetic program for Israel — Jewish prophecies will be fulfilled literally in the future. The Rapture (secret catching away of the Church before the Great Tribulation) is imminent. Premillennial Second Coming follows the Tribulation.

Central tension: With covenant theology (non-dispensational Reformed view): Is there one covenant of grace running through all of Scripture, or multiple distinct dispensations? Is the Church the fulfillment of Old Testament Israel, or a separate entity? Does God have two distinct peoples (Israel and the Church) with two distinct programs?

Who holds it today: Dallas Theological Seminary tradition; most non-denominational evangelical churches; Southern Baptist churches with prophecy emphasis; John MacArthur (modified); Tim LaHaye (Left Behind series); Moody Bible Institute tradition. Declining in academic influence but still very widespread in evangelical pew.

Covenant Theology

Origin: Reformed tradition; developed through the Westminster Confession of Faith (1647) and the works of Johannes Cocceius (1603–1669)

Core claim: God's relationship with humanity is organized through covenants — not dispensations. The primary theological covenants: the Covenant of Redemption (intra-Trinitarian agreement before creation about salvation); the Covenant of Works (with Adam, condition: obedience); the Covenant of Grace (after the Fall, condition: faith in Christ). The Covenant of Grace is the single redemptive framework running from Genesis 3 through the New Testament — all Old Testament covenants are expressions of it. The Church is the continuation of the covenant community of Israel; infant baptism parallels circumcision as the covenant sign.

Central tension: With Dispensationalism: Is God's plan one continuous covenant or a series of distinct dispensations? Does God have one people or two (Israel and Church)? Is the New Covenant a fulfillment or a replacement of the Old?

Who holds it today: Presbyterian and Reformed denominations; Westminster Seminary; Ligonier Ministries (R.C. Sproul); Banner of Truth Trust; confessional Reformed churches broadly.

Part Nine — Theological Systems That Cut Across Denominations

These theological positions appear across multiple denominations and thought forms:

Liberation Theology

Origin: Latin America, 1960s–1970s; Gustavo Gutiérrez's A Theology of Liberation (1971) as foundational text; emerged from engagement between Catholic theologians and the social conditions of the Latin American poor

Core claim: God has a "preferential option for the poor" — Scripture reveals a God who consistently sides with the marginalized, the oppressed, and the exploited. The Kingdom of God involves social, political, and economic liberation, not only spiritual salvation. Praxis (action) and theological reflection must be in continuous dialogue — theology done from the perspective of the poor rather than from the perspective of the powerful. Structural sin (unjust social systems) is as real as personal sin.

Central tension: With traditional evangelical soteriology: Is salvation primarily about individual spiritual transformation or social structural transformation? With Catholic Thomism: Is theology done primarily through philosophical reasoning (Thomism) or through engagement with social reality (Liberation Theology)? The Vatican under John Paul II was deeply critical of liberation theology for its Marxist influences.

Who holds it today: Latin American Catholic base communities; some mainline Protestant denominations; Black theology (James Cone) is a North American parallel; feminist theology and womanist theology are related streams.

Prosperity Gospel / Word of Faith Theology

Origin: Developed mid-20th century USA; roots in Pentecostal healing evangelism and New Thought influence; Kenneth Hagin Sr. (1917–2003) as primary theological architect; popularized by Kenneth Copeland, Creflo Dollar, Joel Osteen, Paula White, T.D. Jakes (partial)

Core claim: The atonement of Christ provides not only forgiveness of sin but physical health and financial prosperity. Faith is a "force" — positive confession (speaking faith-filled words) activates spiritual laws. Negative confession (acknowledging illness, lack, or doubt) undermines faith and can produce negative outcomes. Tithing and giving to the ministry produces a hundredfold material return. Believers have authority to "name and claim" desired outcomes through specific faith declarations.

Central tension: With mainstream evangelical theology: The atonement does not guarantee physical health and material wealth in this life. Suffering can be part of God's purposes. With Reformed theology: God's sovereignty means outcomes are not controlled by human faith declarations. The "health and wealth gospel" is seen as a distortion of the gospel by most mainstream Protestant theologians.

Who holds it today: Predominates in some Pentecostal and charismatic networks; largest in Global South Christianity; significant in African Pentecostalism; multiple major American megachurches (Lakewood, Kenneth Copeland Ministries, Creflo Dollar Ministries).

Open Theism

Origin: Developed in American evangelical theology; Gregory Boyd, Clark Pinnock, John Sanders as primary proponents; Open Theism: The God Who Risks (Sanders, 1998) as key text

Core claim: God does not have exhaustive foreknowledge of future free human choices. God is genuinely open to the future in the sense that He does not determine or infallibly know what free creatures will do. This makes prayer genuinely meaningful (God can be moved to respond), preserves genuine human freedom, and provides a theodicy for suffering (God did not foreordain evil acts).

Central tension: With classical theism (Catholic, Orthodox, most Protestant): God's omniscience includes infallible foreknowledge of all future events, including free human choices. Classical theism holds that God's foreknowledge does not determine human choices. Open Theism considers this incoherent and opts for genuinely limited divine foreknowledge instead. The Evangelical Theological Society expelled Clark Pinnock and John Sanders in 2002 for open theism (later reinstated).

Who holds it today: A minority position within evangelical Christianity; some moderate Baptist and Free Will Baptist circles; Pinnock's and Boyd's followings; considered outside orthodox Christianity by many evangelical institutions.

Cessationism vs. Continuationism

Origin: Cessationism: the spiritual gifts of tongues, prophecy, healing, and miracles ceased with the death of the apostles and the completion of the New Testament canon. Cessationism developed primarily in Reformed/Presbyterian theology. Continuationism: these gifts continue to operate in the church today.

Core claim: Cessationism: gifts were given to authenticate the apostles' message; once the canon was complete, the authenticating gifts were no longer needed. Continuationism: nothing in Scripture teaches that the gifts would cease; the same Spirit who gave them at Pentecost gives them today.

Central tension: This is one of the most practically significant divisions within Protestantism — determining whether tongues, prophecy, and miraculous healing are expected experiences of ordinary Christian life or aberrations.

Who holds it today: Cessationism: John MacArthur (Grace to You), Master's Seminary, Reformed and Presbyterian churches broadly. Continuationism: all Pentecostal and charismatic traditions; many non-denominational churches; Third Wave charismatic movement. Wayne Grudem's "open but cautious" position is a widely held middle ground.

Complementarianism vs. Egalitarianism

Origin: These are positions on gender roles in church and family. The debate intensified in the 1970s–1980s with the ordination of women in mainline denominations.

Core claim: Complementarianism: men and women are equal in dignity but have different, complementary roles — specifically, the roles of pastor/elder/husband/father are reserved for men. Based on specific New Testament texts (1 Timothy 2:12; 1 Corinthians 14:34; Ephesians 5:22). Egalitarianism: differences in role/function between men and women in the church and home are cultural and contextual, not theological mandates — women can hold any leadership role including pastor/elder.

Central tension: This debate cuts across almost every Protestant denomination. Several denominations have split over it. The Southern Baptist Convention's statement that women may not serve as senior pastors contributed to the removal of Saddleback Church (Rick Warren) from the SBC in 2023.

Who holds it today: Complementarianism: SBC, PCA, Acts 29, Southern Baptist institutions, most conservative evangelical. Egalitarianism: PCUSA, UMC, ELCA, Episcopal, CBE International (Christians for Biblical Equality), many non-denominational churches.

Part Ten — Quick Comparison: What Each Branch Believes

The following covers the five most frequently debated theological questions across all Christian traditions:

Salvation — How Does a Person Enter Right Relationship With God?

Catholic: Faith + works + sacraments + cooperation with grace; justification as a process of moral transformation (not merely legal declaration); the sacrament of baptism regenerates; mortal sin can sever the relationship.

Orthodox: Theosis (deification) — participation in the divine nature through the sacraments, ascetic practice, and the transformation of the whole person; salvation as healing of human nature rather than primarily legal acquittal.

Lutheran: Justification by faith alone (Sola Fide); forensic declaration of righteousness; Christ's righteousness credited to the believer; baptism regenerates; salvation cannot be lost.

Reformed/Calvinist: Election by grace alone (Sola Gratia); faith is a gift of God, not a human act; double predestination (some elected to salvation, others to condemnation in some formulations); perseverance of the saints guaranteed.

Arminian/Methodist: Universal atonement; prevenient grace enables but doesn't compel faith; salvation received by faith; entire sanctification possible; salvation can theoretically be lost by persistent unbelief.

Baptist: Individual conversion experience (being "born again"); baptism as public confession, not means of salvation; eternal security (once saved, always saved — in most Baptist traditions); no works component to justification.

Pentecostal: Salvation + baptism in the Holy Spirit as a second work (evidenced by tongues) + divine healing in the atonement; salvation by grace through faith but Spirit baptism as additional empowerment.

The Lord's Supper — What Happens at Communion?

Catholic: Transubstantiation — the substance of the bread and wine becomes the body and blood of Christ while the accidents (appearance) remain. Re-presentation of Christ's sacrifice.

Orthodox: Mysterion — a real change occurs; Christ is truly present; the how is a divine mystery not to be philosophically systematized.

Lutheran: Real Presence — Christ's body and blood truly present "in, with, and under" the bread and wine; the substance of bread and wine remains (distinct from transubstantiation).

Reformed: Spiritual Presence — Christ is spiritually present through the faith of the believer; the Lord's Supper is not merely a memorial but a genuine spiritual feeding; the bread and wine remain what they are.

Baptist/Evangelical: Memorial — the bread and juice are symbols only, commemorating Christ's death; no real or spiritual presence in the elements themselves.

Quaker: No sacraments — all of life is sacramental; no external rite needed.

Baptism — Who Gets Baptized and How?

Catholic/Orthodox/Lutheran/Anglican: Infant baptism (paedobaptism); baptism regenerates or at minimum initiates into the covenant community; mode varies (sprinkling, pouring, or immersion).

Reformed/Presbyterian: Infant baptism; the child of at least one believing parent receives the covenant sign; baptism is not regenerating but is the sign of the covenant of grace (parallel to circumcision).

Baptist/Pentecostal/Non-Denominational: Believer's baptism only (credobaptism); only those who personally profess faith are baptized; baptism by immersion only in most cases; baptism is an act of obedience and public confession, not a means of salvation.

Churches of Christ: Believer's baptism by immersion; baptism for the remission of sins (salvifically necessary in the tradition's reading of Acts 2:38).

Church Governance — Who Is in Charge?

Episcopal: Bishops govern; hierarchical; includes Catholic (Pope at apex), Orthodox (Patriarch/bishops), Anglican (bishops), Methodist (bishops), some Lutherans.

Presbyterian: Elders (presbyters) govern through representative assemblies at local, regional, and national levels; no monarchical bishops; includes most Reformed/Presbyterian denominations.

Congregational: Each local church is self-governing; no external authority over the local congregation; includes most Baptist, most non-denominational, Congregational churches, many Pentecostal churches.

How the Documents in This Series Relate

This Quick Reference Companion sits alongside the following dedicated deep-dive documents in the Haligric Research Integration Series. Each of the documents below provides the full treatment — theology, history, ceremonies, controversies — for its specific tradition:

Roman Catholicism master — Roman Catholic theology, sacraments, history, controversies

Eastern Orthodoxy master — Orthodox theology, Divine Liturgy, theosis, the icons

Christianity Origins master — The early church, the councils, the creeds, the canon

Christianity Denominations master — Overview of 14 major branches

Christianity Edges master — UU, New Apostolic Reformation, Word of Faith edges

Christianity Mystical Tradition master — Christian mysticism across traditions

Lutheranism master — Luther, the Reformation, Lutheran theology and practice

Reformed/Calvinism master — Calvin, TULIP, Westminster Confession, Reformed practice

Anglicanism master — Henry VIII to contemporary Anglican Communion

Methodism master — Wesley, Methodist theology, the UMC split

Baptist Tradition master — Believer's baptism, soul competency, Baptist diversity

Pentecostalism master — Azusa Street, the gifts, classical Pentecostal denominations

Evangelical Christianity master — What evangelicalism is and isn't

Seventh-day Adventism master — Sabbath, Ellen White, Adventist theology

Jehovah's Witnesses master — The Watch Tower, non-Trinitarian theology, practice

Christian Science master — Mary Baker Eddy, matter as illusion, healing practice

Unitarian Universalism master — UU theology, the seven principles, UU diversity

LDS/Mormon master — Joseph Smith, the Book of Mormon, LDS theology and practice

Grand Rising. Two billion Christians. Thousands of denominations. One carpenter. The tradition has never stopped arguing about what he meant — and the arguments have produced cathedrals, crusades, hospitals, liberation movements, inquisitions, hymns, heresies, and the most culturally productive intellectual tradition in Western history. This map does not resolve the arguments. It locates them. Grand Rising.